Redemption

Reconstruction, Part 3

15 MINUTE HISTORY · NARRATION SCRIPT · 2,153 WORDS · ABOUT 12:50

> ***Driving question:*** *Five years after he was elected, a Black state senator was shot in the street and nobody stopped it. How does a country go from that to this? And why did nobody stop it?*

Underlined = vocabulary card on screen · *italic* = spoken with emphasis · timestamps are estimates until the voice is recorded

0:00 A Christmas Drink

A man talked a state senator into a Christmas drink. As their glasses touched, someone fired through the window.

It was the Christmas holidays of 1875, in Clinton, Mississippi. The senator was Charles Caldwell. The blacksmith from the last episode. Born enslaved. Then a lawmaker.

Months later, his wife, Margaret Ann Caldwell, testified under oath to a committee of the U.S. Senate. "When did he die?" they asked. "Thursday night," she said, "in the Christmas." Then she told them what happened.

He was shot in a store's cellar. He called for help. Nobody came. He asked to be carried outside, because, in her words, he "wanted to die in the open air, and did not want to die like a dog closed up."

They carried him into the street. And a crowd of armed men shot him again, many times.

Before they did, according to a minister who was there, he said this. "Remember when you kill me you kill a gentleman and a brave man. Never say you killed a coward."

Five years earlier, Caldwell had been elected to the state senate. So how does a country go from that to this? And why did nobody stop it?

We'll come back to Clinton. And to the question his wife kept asking: why did they kill him?

1:49 The Night

Here's the wall so far. Congress sent the army back into the South. Black men voted, and about 2,000 of them held office. The 15th Amendment wrote the vote into the Constitution. But most freedpeople still didn't own land. And the whole thing rested on two things: votes, and the soldiers who protected them.

Somebody had already figured out how to attack both.

In 1866, six Confederate veterans in Pulaski, Tennessee, started a club. They gave it a strange name: the **Ku Klux Klan**. Within a couple of years, it had spread across the South.

They rode at night, in masks and robes. They whipped, burned and killed. Their targets were Black voters, Black officeholders, teachers at Black schools, churches, and white Republicans too.

Night mattered. Under slavery, white patrols had controlled the roads after dark. Since freedom, Black Southerners had used the night for church meetings, political clubs, and visiting family. The Klan wanted the night back.

And the goal was simple. Keep Black men from voting, and the Republican governments would fall.

This was terrorism. Violence meant to frighten a whole group of people into giving up their rights. And it worked, at first.

2:55 Protection

Then the federal government hit back.

Between 1870 and 1871, Congress passed a series of **Enforcement Acts**. The biggest is often called the Ku Klux Klan Act. They made it a federal crime to use force to stop someone from voting, and they let the President use the army against it.

President Grant used it. In October 1871, he declared nine counties in South Carolina to be in rebellion. He suspended **habeas corpus** there. That's the right not to be held in jail without being charged with a crime. Suspending it meant the army could arrest suspects and hold them.

Soldiers and federal marshals arrested hundreds of men. Hundreds more turned themselves in and confessed. Federal courts held trials.

And the Klan, as an organization, was largely broken.

Hold onto that. Because it proves something. When the federal government decided to protect Black voters with real force, it worked.

On the card, *protection* gets its check mark.

The question was whether the government would keep deciding that.

3:51 Colfax

In 1872, Louisiana had an election so disputed that both sides claimed to have won the state. And the next spring, in the small town of Colfax, that fight turned deadly.

Easter Sunday, 1873. Black men, some of them Union veterans, were guarding the courthouse for the Republican officials. A white militia surrounded them, with a cannon.

The courthouse was set on fire. Men who surrendered were shot. How many died? We don't know exactly. At least 60 Black men. Possibly more than 150.

It's called the **Colfax Massacre**.

Federal prosecutors charged some of the attackers under the Enforcement Acts. The case went all the way to the Supreme Court.

And in 1876, the Court threw the convictions out. Its reasoning was this: the 14th Amendment stops *states* from denying people equal protection. It doesn't cover private citizens attacking other private citizens.

That means it was up to the state of Louisiana to punish the mob. The same state where the mob had won.

Nobody was ever punished for Colfax.

4:53 Tired

Meanwhile, up North, people had other things on their minds.

In 1873, one of the country's biggest banks collapsed, and it took the economy down with it. It's called the **Panic of 1873**. A depression followed that lasted for years. Businesses failed. Workers lost their jobs.

When you're worried about your own paycheck, a fight in Louisiana feels very far away.

Then there were the scandals. Grant was honest himself, but people around him weren't. The worst was the **Whiskey Ring**. Government tax officials let whiskey makers skip their taxes, in exchange for a cut. One of the men charged was the President's own private secretary.

Reformers who had once fought slavery now turned to a new cause: cleaning up the government. Black rights slid down their list.

In 1874, voters gave Democrats control of the House for the first time since before the war.

Republicans managed one last law on their way out, the **Civil Rights Act of 1875**. It banned discrimination in hotels, theaters and trains. Almost nobody enforced it. The Supreme Court struck it down eight years later.

More and more Northerners talked about the South as a problem they were tired of solving.

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Quick thing before we go on. If you're getting something out of this series, hit subscribe. It's free, and I promise there's no Whiskey Ring involved.

6:08 The Bank

And then there was the bank.

In 1865, Congress created the **Freedman's Savings Bank**, a bank for freedpeople. Many depositors believed the government stood behind it. It didn't.

Tens of thousands of people opened accounts. Soldiers saved their pay. Churches saved. Families put away a few dollars at a time, hoping to buy a farm someday. Forty acres, maybe.

But the men running the bank made risky loans, some of them to their friends.

In 1874, with the bank near collapse, its trustees brought in the most famous Black man in America, Frederick Douglass, to be its president. He even put in 10,000 dollars of his own money.

It was too late. Within months, the bank closed. More than 60,000 depositors were owed almost 3 million dollars.

The government didn't make them whole. Over the years, only about half of what they were owed was ever paid back. Many people never saw a cent.

For a lot of families, that was their savings, and their trust, gone at once.

7:05 Mississippi, 1875

Which brings us back to Mississippi, in 1875.

That year, Mississippi's Democrats made a decision. They were going to win the next election by any means necessary. Armed clubs of white men showed up at Republican meetings. People called it the **Mississippi Plan**.

In September, about 2,000 Black Mississippians and their families gathered for a Republican rally and barbecue just outside Clinton. Charles Caldwell's town. Men from a nearby town broke it up. Shots were fired. At least eight people died, including three white men.

Over the next few days, armed white men hunted Black people across the county. Somewhere between 30 and 50 were killed.

The governor of Mississippi was Adelbert Ames. The carpetbagger from Maine, the one who got Jefferson Davis's old Senate seat. He telegraphed President Grant for troops.

The answer came back from Grant's attorney general, quoting the President. The whole public, it said, was "tired out with these annual autumnal outbreaks in the South."

Translation: the North was done.

So Ames raised a militia of his own, and he put Charles Caldwell in charge of part of it. Caldwell marched a company through the area to deliver guns. To many white Democrats, that marked him.

Then Ames made a peace deal and disbanded the militia. On Election Day, Democrats swept Mississippi. In some counties full of Black voters, the Republican vote fell to almost nothing.

And at the end of December, Charles Caldwell was talked into a Christmas drink.

His wife told the Senate why she believed they killed him: "for obeying Governor Ames; and that was all they had against him."

The white Democrats who took over called themselves **Redeemers**, and what they had done, **Redemption**. To redeem means to save. In their story, they had saved the South. From people like Charles Caldwell.

8:54 Two Sets of Results

By the next year, there were only three Southern states left with Republican governments: South Carolina, Louisiana and Florida.

And then came the presidential election of 1876. Republican Rutherford B. Hayes against Democrat Samuel Tilden.

Tilden won more votes. But not, it turned out, clearly enough. In those same three states, both parties claimed to have won, and each sent its own set of electoral votes to Washington. Two sets of results. One country.

The winner needed 185 electoral votes. Tilden had 184. The disputed votes would decide everything.

For months, nobody knew who the next president would be. Congress created a special commission of 15 men to sort it out. It voted along party lines, 8 to 7, and gave every disputed vote to Hayes.

Democrats could still have blocked it in Congress. They didn't. Why? There's no proof of a written deal. But in what's called the **Compromise of 1877**, the understanding was this: Hayes becomes president, and the federal government stops propping up the last Republican governments in the South.

In April 1877, Hayes ordered the soldiers guarding the statehouses in South Carolina and Louisiana to leave. Soon after, both Republican governments collapsed.

Every Southern state was now in the hands of the Redeemers.

And that's usually where the history books say it: Reconstruction was over.

10:07 Voteless

But Black Southerners didn't lose everything in 1877. Black men kept voting in many places for years. Some kept winning office.

What changed was who was protecting them. Now, nobody was.

Over the next 25 years, Southern states took the vote back. Not with a law that said "no Black voters." The 15th Amendment didn't allow that. They used the gaps we talked about in the last episode.

A **poll tax**: a fee you had to pay to vote, more than many poor farmers could spare.

A **literacy test**: a reading test, graded by white officials, who decided who passed.

A **grandfather clause**: an escape hatch that let a man skip those rules if his grandfather had been able to vote. Which, in the South, meant white men.

Here's what it did. In 1896, Louisiana had about 130,000 Black men registered to vote. Eight years later, it had about 1,300.

Along with it came laws that split almost everything by race: schools, trains, waiting rooms, water fountains. They're called **Jim Crow** laws.

So go back to the three words from Edisto Island. *Landless.* Still. *Homeless.* For many, still. And *Voteless.* Written back in.

11:11 A Few Acres

So step all the way back and look at the whole wall. Three episodes. And the question from the very start: what does it take to make freedom real?

Here's what Reconstruction suggests. Three things. The law. The land. And someone willing to protect both.

Reconstruction delivered the law. The 13th Amendment ended slavery. The 14th made freedpeople citizens, with equal protection of the laws. The 15th protected the vote.

It never delivered the land. Most of Edisto Island went back to its old owners. Stevens's plan died with him. Most freedpeople ended up sharecropping on someone else's ground.

And it delivered protection only while the North was willing. When the army enforced the law, the Klan broke. When the army left, the law stayed on paper.

Was Reconstruction a failure? People have argued about that ever since.

One answer: yes. By 1900, most Black Southerners were landless again, and voteless again.

Another answer: it built things that lasted. Schools. Churches. Families that found each other. A generation of Black leaders. And three amendments that never went away. Some historians call them a second founding.

In 1954, the Supreme Court used the 14th Amendment's equal protection to end segregated schools. In 1965, Congress finally put real force behind the 15th. The words written down in the 1860s were still there, waiting.

Remember those three men on Edisto Island? They asked their President for "A home if It be but A few acres." They didn't get it.

But their country did write something down that decade, about citizens, about equal protection, about the vote. It would take almost a hundred years for the country to start living up to it.

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